
We Can Fight for South Africa Without Burning South Africa

A media opinion piece on protest, public violence prevention, and collective safety

By Nomfundo Mogapi

South Africa is restless.

We can feel it in the anger, the rumours, the online conversations, the community meetings and the growing language of blame. We can feel it in communities tired of poverty, unemployment, unsafe streets, collapsing public services and political promises that have not arrived in people's daily lives.

This restlessness is not imagined.

According to Statistics South Africa, the official unemployment rate rose to 32.7% in the first quarter of 2026. Among young people, the crisis is even more painful: in Q1 2026, 4.7 million young people aged 15 to 34 were unemployed, while 10.6 million were outside the labour force. More than four in ten young people aged 15 to 34 were not in employment, education or training. These are not just numbers. They are lives suspended. They are homes under pressure. They are young people waking up every morning to a country that has not found a place for them.

So, when people are angry, we must not be surprised.

But we must be careful how we name this moment.

This is not only about a march. It is not only about one issue, one group, one slogan or one day. It is about a deeper restlessness in the psyche of the country. It is about a society carrying unresolved economic injustice, unresolved social pain and unresolved historical wounds.

South Africans have a constitutional right to protest. Section 17 of the Constitution protects the right of everyone, peacefully and unarmed, to assemble, demonstrate, picket and present petitions. Protest is one of the languages of democracy. It is one of the ways people make visible the pain that power often ignores.

But the right to protest also carries a responsibility to protect life, dignity, public safety and the country itself.

Our concern comes from years of work with communities, organisations, leaders and systems that are carrying pain. It also comes from research conducted through the Centre for the Study of Violence and Reconciliation and related work on collective violence, protest and community mobilisation. In that work, we sought to understand what makes protests move from peaceful to violent.

What we learnt is that protests often begin with genuine grievances and the best intentions from organisers. People gather because they want to be heard. They gather because they want jobs, safety, services, accountability and dignity. They gather because they feel abandoned by those in power.

But even when a protest begins peacefully, it can still escalate.

Research by the Institute for Security Studies and CSVr has shown that a range of factors can influence whether protests become violent, including the conduct of leaders, law enforcement agencies, government departments, private companies and other actors who may be the target of protest. This matters because protest violence is not simply about 'bad people' in a crowd. It is also about context, leadership, policing, provocation, frustration, preparation and whether trusted people are present to de-escalate.

The Institute for Security Studies has also tracked incidents of public protest and violence since 2013 through its Protest and Public Violence Monitor. Earlier ISS analysis on water and sanitation-related protests found that, between January 2013 and April 2021, 378 of 585 recorded protests turned violent. This tells us that escalation is not a fringe risk. It is a pattern that South Africa must take seriously.

As more people join a protest, as emotions heighten, as rumours spread and as anger becomes contagious, the emotional temperature of the crowd can change. Groupthink begins to take over. The limbic system is activated. People begin to feel anonymous. Personal responsibility weakens. The crowd can begin to do things that many individuals would never have imagined themselves doing alone.

In the CSVr study, this was referred to as the 'crowd within the crowd'.

This is the group that may not have started the protest. It may not carry the original intention. It may not be accountable to the organisers. But once emotions rise, this crowd within the crowd can hijack the moment. It can turn pain into destruction. It can turn legitimate grievance into violence. It can leave communities more wounded than before.

This is why South Africa must take the current moment seriously.

We are living in a country where unresolved economic and social justice grievances have accumulated over time. People are unemployed. People are hungry. People are unsafe. People feel abandoned by the state. People feel unseen by those in power. Many experience democracy as a promise that has not reached their homes, schools, clinics, streets or bodies.

This social pain sits on top of unresolved historical pain.

The work of organisations such as the Centre for Mental Wellness and Leadership, the Institute for Healing of Memories, HealSA and the Institute for Justice and Reconciliation reminds us that South Africa remains a wounded society. Apartheid violence, poverty, humiliation, gender-based violence, community violence, corruption, inequality and repeated betrayal have shaped the nervous system of the country. CSVr's long-term work has also warned that violence in South Africa did not disappear after apartheid; it mutated into different forms, including community violence, gender-based violence, xenophobic violence, structural violence and public unrest.

Xenowatch has recorded hundreds of incidents of xenophobic violence in South Africa. Its 2021 report recorded 873 incidents between 1994 and November 2021, and noted that, since 2008, xenophobic violence had resulted in at least 612 deaths, more than 122,000 people displaced, and 6,306 shops or properties looted or damaged. These numbers are not included here to shift the whole conversation back to migration. They are included to remind us that once public anger is organised towards a target, the consequences can be devastating and long-lasting.

In such a context, any grievance that is emotional enough, organised enough and packaged as the answer to people's suffering can become dangerous.

The issue is not whether South Africans have a right to raise concerns. They do.

The issue is how those concerns are raised, who carries the message, what emotions are activated, what targets are created, and what kind of country is left behind after the mobilisation.

This is why we need more peace carriers.

Peace carriers are people who can speak to pain without activating hatred. They do not deny injustice. They do not shame people for being angry. They do not pretend that poverty, unemployment, crime, corruption and failed public services are not real. Instead, they help people organise their pain towards accountability, justice, repair and rebuilding.

Peace carriers can say: your suffering is real, but destruction will not heal it.

They can say: demand jobs, services, safety and accountability, but do not burn the country you are trying to save.

They can say: face injustice, but protect peace.

They can say: fight for South Africa without destroying South Africa.

On the other hand, there are trauma carriers.

Trauma carriers also know how to speak to people's pain. They know how to name humiliation, anger and abandonment. But instead of transforming that pain into constructive action, they activate it towards rage, blame, violence and burning. They may sound like they are speaking for the people, but the energy they release can leave communities more unsafe, more divided and more broken.

In this moment, South Africa needs more peace carriers than trauma carriers.

We need leaders, organisers, faith communities, traditional leaders, youth leaders, women's groups, civil society, journalists, teachers, social workers, councillors, local businesses and ordinary citizens who can help regulate the emotional temperature of the country.

We need people who can identify early warning signs.

We need people who can see when a protest is at risk of being hijacked.

We need people who can notice when language is becoming dehumanising, when rumours are spreading, when fear is being amplified, when young people are being mobilised towards harm, and when the crowd within the crowd is beginning to take over.

We need peacebuilders in communities who can ask difficult questions before the fire starts:

Who is organising this action?

What is the real grievance?

Who is being targeted?

What language is being used?

Who benefits if this becomes violent?

Who will be harmed if this escalates?

What happens the day after?

What kind of South Africa will be left behind?

This is also an appeal to South Africans who may support the march, or who feel that the grievances being raised are valid.

Be conscious of how this work is done.

Be conscious of what is being activated.

Be conscious of who joins the crowd.

Be conscious of the language being used.

Be conscious of those who may hijack the pain of communities for other agendas.

Be conscious that even legitimate grievances can be redirected towards violence when the collective nervous system is already activated.

The question is not only what people are marching against.

The deeper question is: what are we marching towards?

After 30 June, what kind of South Africa do we want to wake up to?

Do we want a South Africa more divided, more wounded, more violent and more afraid? Or do we want a South Africa where people's grievances are heard, where leaders are held accountable, where communities are safe, where public systems work, where dignity is protected and where justice is pursued without burning the country?

The task of this moment is not to choose between justice and peace.

The task is to insist on both.

Peace without justice becomes silence. Justice without peace can become revenge. South Africa needs something deeper: collective safety and justice.

We need to transform woundedness that can easily be activated towards violence into healed energy that can fight for justice while protecting peace.

We can be angry without becoming violent.

We can demand accountability without dehumanising others.

We can face injustice without burning the country.

We can fight for South Africa while strengthening South Africa.

The question before us is simple but urgent:

After 30 June, what kind of South Africa do we want to be left with?

Source Notes and Factual Basis

1. Statistics South Africa, Quarterly Labour Force Survey Q1 2026 and 'South Africa's Youth and the Labour Market in Q1 2026': official unemployment rate of 32.7%; 4.7 million unemployed youth aged 15-34; 10.6 million outside the labour force; NEET rate of 45.6% for ages 15-34.
2. Constitution of the Republic of South Africa, Chapter 2, Section 17: everyone has the right, peacefully and unarmed, to assemble, demonstrate, picket and present petitions.
3. Institute for Security Studies, Protest and Public Violence Monitor: tracks incidents of public protest and violence in South Africa from 2013 onward.
4. Institute for Security Studies, 'Lessons in preventing violent protest in South Africa' (2021): water and sanitation delivery failures resulted in 585 protests from January 2013 to April 2021, of which 378, or about 65%, turned violent.
5. Xenowatch, 'Xenophobic Violence in South Africa: 1994-2021' (2021): 873 recorded incidents between 1994 and November 2021; since 2008, at least 612 deaths, 122,298 people displaced and 6,306 shops/properties looted or damaged. The report notes that actual numbers are likely to be higher because of underreporting.
6. The conceptual language of 'peace carriers', 'trauma carriers', 'collective safety and justice' and the 'crowd within the crowd' is drawn from CMWL/CSVR-informed practice, meeting reflections, and public violence prevention work referenced in the drafting process.

Stats SA youth labour market: <https://www.statssa.gov.za/?p=19526>

Constitution Section 17: <https://www.justice.gov.za/constitution/chp02.html>

ISS Protest and Public Violence Monitor: <https://crimehub.org/topics/protest-and-public-violence-monitor>

ISS violent protest prevention article: <https://issafrica.org/iss-today/lessons-in-preventing-violent-protest-in-south-africa>

Xenowatch report: https://www.xenowatch.ac.za/wp-content/uploads/2022/04/Xenowatch-Report-2021_Final.pdf